board.[2] From several accounts, covered extensively in the media, most migrants were of the opinion that with very meagre savings, they wouldn't be able to pay rent and put food on the table. So, instead, they'd use their savings to find a way to get home, to the village. However, due to the curbs on passenger transport since the lockdown, several of them decided to make the journey of hundreds of kilometres by foot. This put the government in a tough spot. They could not, under any circumstance, allow such a mass exodus at this point in time. Health infrastructure in the rural parts of the country was very weak, there was no awareness of the disease and allowing the virus to spread unchecked to the villages would be catastrophic. So, up until the communication about the virus had percolated to rural India and the infrastructure had been strengthened enough to be able to handle positive COVID-19 cases, the government would have to stop the migration. And hence, keeping in mind the safety of the millions of unexposed rural Indians, the Indian government ordered the states to close borders. However, to allay some fears, the empowered group responsible for overseeing logistics ensured that food grains were in ample supply and that every single Indian with a ration card, regardless of domicile, would get free access to their promised quota. Furthering that intent, on 27 March, four days after the announcement of national lockdown, the Ministry of Home Affairs sent out an advisory to state governments and UTs to provide adequate support including food and shelter to the migrants. The same advisory further stated that states and UTs should explore measures, with the support of non-profit organizations, to provide food, shelter and basic amenities, such as clean drinking water and sanitation facilities to informally employed workers, in particular to stranded migrant workers. They were also advised to make these vulnerable groups aware of the measures taken by the government, including provision of free food grains and other essential items through the Public Distribution System (PDS) and streamline the distribution of such items.[3]

However, a huge glitch in the system was the absence of ration card portability which would compel the states to officially provide benefits of the free food grains scheme through the PDS. What this meant was that since migrants, especially short-term migrants, did not have a ration card in their destination city which at this point it was still defined by domicile requirements, they would be left out of the free food grains welfare scheme